

athletes and was one of the longest-standing records in Indian track and field. Ancy is more than aware of just how significant the jump is.

"I know Anju ma'am is a legend and I'm also aiming to be like her. I also want to be a world-class jumper," she says.

The jump might have come now but those who know her had long expected something special from her.

"You know how you need a lot of funds to play sport. There's not a lot of support. And my father was an auto driver but he never let me face any challenge when I was trying to become an athlete. If he didn't have money for something, he'd borrow it from his friends. He treated me like a princess. He had the spirit of a sportsperson and he would always tell me that he was fulfilling his dream through me," Ancy tells *Sportstar*.

With her father firmly in her corner, she progressed steadily through the junior ranks and made it to the national camp in Bengaluru in 2021 where she began training under coach Anoop Kumar.

"Even then she stood out because she was this ball of energy. You knew she was waiting to explode. It was a matter of time," says Anoop, who continues to coach her to this day.

More than just a national record

Anoop recalls that what stood out about Ancy was not just her raw potential — he says she is perhaps the fastest Indian long jumper on the runway approach — but her mentality.

"She wasn't someone who was easily satisfied. Anju's record hadn't been touched for over 20 years but she was already looking beyond it. I remember one of the first conversations I had with her and she said she wanted to be a 7m jumper," he says.

Ancy remembers the conversation as well.

"I knew what Anju ma'am's record was but I was never chasing it. I only wanted to be a world-class athlete. I remember when I went to the



Flying finish: Ancy's 6.88m jump helped her top the podium pipping Shaili Singh's 6.67m effort and Mubassina Mohammed's 6.53m. BISWARANJAN ROUT

Commonwealth Games for the first time as a 21-year-old. I saw how far some of the top athletes were jumping. I was so encouraged by their speed and ability.

"I too wanted to improve to be like them. It never crossed my mind that I had to cross this mark or any other," she says.

Even when she first started enjoying international success — beating more fancied opponents to win silver at the Asian Games in Hangzhou in 2023 — Ancy was always looking beyond.

"She had a few injuries towards the end of 2023 and in the run-up to the Paris Olympics. Despite that, she could still have found a way to qualify for the Olympics through rankings but she told me, 'Sir, I don't want to go like this. I want to go when I really deserve it. I want to prove I belong at this level,'" he recalls.

That ambition became harder still to accomplish when, in 2025, Ancy suffered a hormonal issue that caused her to gain weight rapidly. The extra kilos weighed her down and her form dipped unexpectedly. After tests finally diagnosed the cause, Ancy underwent an intense training and diet regimen to get into the shape she wanted.

"I love rice and *biryani* but I completely cut everything like that

out of my diet. I know that if you want to be world-class, you have to sacrifice these things," she remembers.

At the start of the 2026 season, the change was dramatic. Ancy lost eight kilos from 63 to 55 and dropped to 13 per cent body fat. As the weight dropped, she started to soar.

At the Federation Cup in Ranchi last month, Ancy leapt a Personal Best of 6.76m to win gold. But while it took her to second on the Indian all-time list behind only Anju, it wasn't enough to meet the Athletics Federation of India's qualification mark for the Commonwealth Games.

Although it was a big enough mark for a case to be made for Ancy to be included in the Indian team for Glasgow, and while athletes across other sports have fought to be included in Indian teams with less in support of their claim, Ancy made it clear very early that she wasn't going to fight to be included.

At the Inter-State Championships — which also served as a qualification event for the Asian Games — there would be nothing left to chance.

Nervous before the start of the competition, Ancy calmed herself by jumping a massive 6.73m right away. That was the furthest she had ever